Waterdeep Encounter

Book Wyrm's Birthday Gift



By Al Stover

Synopsis

Residents and business owners of Trollskull Alley are celebrating the birthday of Rishaal The Page-Turner (dragonborn, he/him), owner of Book Wyrm's Treasure. When the party arrives and sees all of the fanfare, they are greeted by Trollskull Alley investigator Vincent Trench (he/him). The PI explains that Rishaal doesn't usually like celebrating his birthday, yet Vincent and the other alley residents wanted to make this year special for the dragonborn. Since Rishaal owns a bookstore and loves books, Vincent tasks the party with gathering stories for an anthology they'll give to Rishaal as a present.

This encounter can be run for any character level. The party size can range from 1-5 characters.

Setting

The encounter takes place in Waterdeep's Trollskull Alley. Dungeon Masters can put this encounter into their "Waterdeep: Dragon Heist" campaign, or any adventure set in the City of Splendors.

If the characters are from "Waterdeep: Dragon Heist " campaign and already own Trollskull Manor, they're likely familiar with their alley neighbors, including Rishaal.

If the party doesn't own Trollskull Manor, or hasn't been to Trollskull Alley, they could be just passing through and came across this elaborate party.

Encounter Start

The encounter begins when the party enters Trollskull Alley.

The Dungeon Master will read the following description.

Trollskull Alley is filled with laughter, singing, and pouring of drinks as a party is in full swing. Sitting at a large table is an uncomfortable dragonborn who nibbles on a piece of chocolate cake, then smiles as an inebriated couple walks up to him and shouts "Happy Birthday!" As you walk further into the party, a human wearing a trenchcoat greets you with a smile while holding a leather bound tome.

Vincent Trench greets the adventurers and hands one of them a leatherbound book. He explains that it's Rishaal's birthday. If asked why Rishaal doesn't look happy, Vincent replies that the dragonborn doesn't like celebrating his birthday. Recognizing they're adventurers, Vincent asks the party to help him in gathering stories and fill the book's pages. Once they're finished, they'll present the book to Rishaal.

Vincent adds that he's already filled the first several pages with stories from himself and other business owners in Trollskull Alley.

If the characters look inside, they'll see the following entries

- Vincent wrote about a case where he and the City Watch teamed up to stop a group of shapechangers blackmailing a noble family.
- Embric (he/him) and Avi (he/him), of Steam and Steel penned an tale where they discover schematics of elven chain armor in Ardeep Forest, as well as their attempts to create it.

- The Bent Nail's Talisolvanar "Tally" Fellbranch (he/him), wrote about the first shield his parents gave him.
- Fala Lefaliir (they/them), of Corellon's Crown, shared a story about the time she and her friend Ziraj accidentally consumed a sleeping potion.

All of the aforementioned NPC's stat blocks can be found in "Waterdeep: Dragon Heist."

Objective

To complete this encounter, characters need to collect stories from at least six more people. A character can use their past adventure, experience or their backstory as one of the entries.

Characters can also mingle with party guests to gather tales. There are ten guests they can talk to.

Anyone attempting to collect a story from a guest will need to succeed a DC 12 Charisma check. Most of these stories from party guests can be ad libbed by the Dungeon Master. Of course, there's always the option to have a player come up with a guest's story.

Characters can speak to the following guests:

1. Eban Lorlei (human, she/they) is a local dog walker who shares the story about her first animal foster, a puppy named Wanda.
2. Teeleef Bramblescar (halfling, she/her) is a member of the Dungsweeper's Guild and writes about the nastiest mess she's cleaned up in the North Ward.
3. The cleric Obaya Uday (human, she/her), writes about her most recent expedition into Undermountain.
4. Vulcara Ripsheef (half-elf, she/her) is a blacksmith from Icewind Dale, who boasts about the time she wrestled a yeti.
5. Octo Brewfist (half-orc, he/him) recently started brewing his own beer. He shares a tale about working his first shift in Shadowdale's Old Skull Inn.
6. Roland Lhal (aasimar, he/him) is the Waterdeep Parks and Recreation Guest Services Coordinator. He writes about the time he and his friends beat up Danilo Thann.
7. Flint (dragonborn, he/him) is the Waterdeep Parks and Recreation Deputy Director. He writes about the first painting class he supervised, which ended in disaster.
8. Delnar Grimaxe (orc, he/him) is a chieftain who reminisces about his first hunt in the mountains.
9. Waterdeep resident Floon Blagmaar (human, he/him), shares a story about him drinking with Renaer Neverember.
10. Mirt (human, he/him), a longtime Waterdeep noble, shares a story of adventuring in Undermountain.

Another way characters can fill the book's pages is to pen down historical facts. Anyone attempting to do this will need to make a History (Intelligence) check about Waterdeep or another area of Faerun. They can also utilize any spells that can help them in this skill check.

What the character is able to remember will depend on their roll.
1-10 - They know basic knowledge about the story they're trying to recall
11-15 - They know great detail about the story.
16 or higher - They know the exact details of the story and can recite it as if they were there themselves.

Conclusion

Once all of the stories are collected, the characters can present the book to Rishaal. The dragonborn accepts it with a genuine smile, thanking them for a wonderful present. He then raises a toast and says how grateful and thankful he is for being among such great friends and neighbors.

Characters can also go around and try some chocolate cake and ale.

If the characters ask why Rishaal doesn't like celebrating his birthday, he explains the sour feelings stemming from an incident during his childhood. He once took notes for a famous adventuring guild. In return, the guild promised to attend Rishaal's birthday party. They never showed. Once he finishes his tale, Rishaal says that the efforts of the characters and his friends made him realize that you can't let one bad birthday ruin future celebrations.

Once again he thanks the characters for making his birthday fun again and he looks forward to next year's celebration.

Credits/Acknowledgements

This encounter takes inspiration from a couple of different sources. First is a viral meme where an adventuring party promised a brass dragon to attend his birthday after he helped them and they didn't hold up their end of the bargain. The other is the "Gravity Falls" episode "Blendin's Game."

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